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# Athlete transitions in a Norwegian professional football academy: transition experiences and parental support

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## ABSTRACT

Even though parents are expected to support their child in an academy football context, little is known about the impact of parental involvement in this period. The aim of the present study was to study perceptions of athletes' and their parents in their athletic transitions in a Norwegian professional football academy. Five parents and five players who had played in a Norwegian professional football academy between the ages of 16 and 18 years were interviewed in retrospect. Both parts described few athletic challenges, level of performance and playing in new positions were considered difficult to handle. Since only one of the players ended up playing professional football, we discuss in which degree the lack of pressure from most parents might have impacted on this fact. The results show however that the support the parents offer is considered important also when these players entered the professional club as junior players.

## Introduction

Selection into talent development programmes generally is considered a critical milestone in an athlete's pathway,<sup>1</sup> even though the long-term effectiveness of such programmes remains debated.<sup>2</sup> In football, these pathways are embodied by professional club academies, whose mandate is to identify promising players and nurture them within development-oriented environments. Launched in 2017, Norway's Academy Classification is a national initiative aimed at optimizing athlete development across the country's professional football clubs.<sup>3</sup> It evaluates each youth academy against 11 performance areas – from coaching competency and training methodology to educational support and player productivity. Based on the total score, clubs receive a 1- to 5-star rating that determines their share of central development funding and highlights where they need to improve.

The classification model has recently been criticized for primarily focusing on academy structure and performance output while overlooking the relational processes that underpin holistic development.<sup>4</sup> Of the relational factors, parents are often the most constant source of practical and emotional support for young players and may especially be important during key transitions such as entry into – and release from – an academy programme. With this backdrop, the present study explores the role of parents for athletes selected into a Norwegian professional football academy, including transitions in and out of the academy as well as within the academy.

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## Previous research

Parental involvement in youth sport has long been recognized as significant in shaping the experiences and outcomes of young athletes. Dorsch and colleagues<sup>5</sup> note that studies on parental involvement in sport traditionally have explored the impact of parental supportive and pressuring behaviours on their child's experiences and psychosocial outcomes. Parental support includes elements such as practical (e.g. providing equipment or transportation), informational (e.g. offering advice or guidance) and emotional support (e.g. showing encouragement and understanding),<sup>6</sup> and has generally been associated with adaptive athlete outcomes, such as sport enjoyment, continued participation and development of positive coping skills.<sup>7</sup> On the other hand, unsupportive or pressurizing behaviours (e.g. criticizing play) exhibited by parents have been linked to unfavourable outcomes for young athletes, such as reduced enjoyment of sports, amotivation and even dropout from participation.<sup>8</sup>

Research has highlighted the limitations of categorizing parental behaviours as solely supportive or pressurizing, as the crucial aspect lies not only in the exhibited behaviours but also in how these actions are perceived and interpreted by young athletes.<sup>9</sup> Moreover, Knight et al.<sup>10</sup> found that athletes' preferences for support fluctuated based on specific contexts and timing, underscoring the interplay between parental behaviours and contextual characteristics. Indeed, Harwood and Knight<sup>11</sup> highlight in their paper on parenting expertise in sport that parents need to adapt to their child's ongoing athletic development, educational decisions, changing support needs and career transitions to appropriately support their child. Therefore, as children undergo transitions in their sports involvement, parents need to adapt their own involvement accordingly, as well as guide and support young athletes through these changes.

Transitions in sports represent important moments in athletes' careers, marked by a significant shift in the demands, expectations, personal development and pressures faced by athletes.<sup>12</sup> To understand the challenges faced by athletes during such transitions, Wylleman & Lavallee's<sup>13</sup> proposed developmental perspective on transitions faced by athletes at athletic, psychological, psychosocial and academic/vocational levels. The athletic level represents changes in the demands (e.g. heightened performance expectations) throughout the phases of initiation, development, mastery and discontinuation. Furthermore, the psychological phase regards the transitions from childhood to adolescence, and further to adulthood. The psychosocial level refers to changes in interpersonal relationships with peers, coaches and parents, whereas the academic and vocational level relates to the transitions from primary education to secondary education, to higher education and finally professional occupation. The model further emphasizes that these transitions often occur at the same time, such as the transition from junior to senior (i.e. development to mastery) typically is conducted while transiting from adolescence to adulthood and from secondary education to higher education.

The transition from junior to senior levels in competitive sports is highlighted as the most difficult sport transition in athletes' careers.<sup>14</sup> Consequently, a significant portion of research on sport transitions has concentrated on this phase. Within this transition, athletes often confront an elevated sports standard, heightened physical and mental demands, and a more intense and competitive sporting culture, as emphasized by qualitative insights from various sports stakeholders, including coaches, science support staff and parents.<sup>15</sup> In their meta-study of qualitative research on the junior to senior-transition in sport, Drew and colleagues<sup>16</sup> identified four overarching themes that impact the quality of junior to senior transitions in sports. They highlighted that the transition is dependent on individual factors (e.g. athletes expectations and understanding of the transition and psychological factors such as confidence and motivation), cultural factors (e.g. culture changes within sport and challenges associated with being a part of a youth culture that conflicts the professional life), intervention strategies (e.g. coping strategies and access to educational programmes to educate young athletes to cope with the transition) and external factors (e.g. access to social support and sources of stress such as coach-

athlete conflicts and inadequate social support). Similarly, in a quantitative study of 177 Greek athletes, Andronikos et al.<sup>17</sup> found personal resources, transition demands and environmental support were the strongest predictors of adaptive adjustment to senior level in sport. However, it is important to acknowledge that most junior athletes don't reach professional level and end up transitioning out of sport or to recreational participation. Although such transition may reduce the stress associated with increased sport standard (see Morris et al.),<sup>18</sup> transiting out of sport may lead to challenges in shift in identity and social network,<sup>19</sup> in addition to the potential stress associated with the transition outcome (e.g. deselection). Therefore, stakeholders have highlighted that the transition process is depending on various athlete characteristics (e.g. understanding the competitive demands and determination to improve and work hard), yet they also highlight the important role of social support from coaches, teammates, friends and family.<sup>20</sup>

Studies have highlighted that parents may facilitate successful transitions through various supportive behaviours, including providing financial assistance, as indicated by Franck and Stambulova,<sup>21</sup> emotional guidance, as demonstrated in the study by Morris et al.<sup>22</sup> and practical/logistical aid, exemplified by actions such as transportation, as shown by Morris.<sup>23</sup> The role of parents in providing emotional support has also been highlighted for professional athletes transitioning out of sport.<sup>24</sup> Moreover, parents may also facilitate how athletes perceive and deal with the transition, as parents have been identified as important in shaping their children's motivation and expectations in sports,<sup>25</sup> as well as fostering resilience.<sup>26</sup>

In summary, evidence suggests athletes face several difficult transitions throughout their sport career, including facing a new sport culture, potential increase in demands and uncertainty regarding their future (see Morris et al.).<sup>27</sup> Although parents are highlighted as important in supporting their child through such transition (see e.g. Drew et al.),<sup>28</sup> existing studies have had a rather broad perspective to understand various factors influencing the transition (see e.g. Franck & Stambulova).<sup>29</sup> Accordingly, the study aimed to investigate the transition experiences of athletes engaged in a professional football academy, focusing on gaining insights into both the athletes' and their parents' perceptions of these transitions, as well as the role parents may play during this period.

## Methodology

This study adopted a qualitative approach, which focuses on the ways people interpret and make sense of their experiences.<sup>30</sup> When the academic interest in sport parenting began, research was done mainly with a quantitative design. In this study, we sought answering questions such as *why*, and a qualitative design was therefore more suitable for this study. Because the aim of this study is to collect in depth information about how both parents and players experience the sport parent role, in the introduction to junior academy football and during the phase, a qualitative design was chosen to be the most suitable. Furthermore, a qualitative design enables collection of a lot of information from a relatively small selection/sample.

The research questions for this study were addressed through an interpretivist paradigm, where understanding of someone's reality cannot be understood through natural science methods, but through their experience of that reality. Furthermore, as the present study wanted to understand perceptions of parents and their children, a relativist ontology position was considered appropriate. Within such a position, social reality is humanly constructed, multiple and subjective,<sup>31</sup> thus, acknowledging that different individuals may have different version of reality. Regarding epistemology, the present study adopts a constructivist understanding of knowledge. Thus, rather than aiming to revealing objective truth, the constructionist epistemology considers knowledge as socially constructed based on how individuals engage with and interpret the world.<sup>32</sup>

## Participants and procedure

A Norwegian professional football club competing at the highest national level was approached by email to help recruit informants. The club was fully briefed on the study's objectives and subsequently asked to identify former academy players and their parents who were willing to provide valuable insights into the parental role both before, during and after the transition from junior to senior levels. To be eligible for participation, the players in question needed to have been part of the academy for a minimum of 3 years (equivalent to the junior period in Norway) and have experienced this transition between three and five years prior. Importantly, while all academy players of the club have ambitions to progress to professional senior football, no specific guidelines or expectations were provided regarding the outcome of this transition. Players and parents who met the inclusion criteria were contacted and informed about the purpose of the study through an information letter distributed through an employee of the academy. Parents who demonstrated interest contacted the first author directly. The players were recruited through their parents. Participants were five male players who 3–5 years earlier had been players of a Norwegian football academy and five of their parents (four fathers, one mother,  $M_{\text{age}} = 55$ ,  $SD = 3.2$ ). To ensure confidentiality of the informants, no further information about them is presented.

Once the participants agreed to participate, times for interviews were arranged. The participants got the choice between a digital or in-person interview. All interviews were conducted individually, eight using Zoom and two by personal encounter. Both parents and players were informed of their right to confidentiality, anonymity and freedom to withdraw from the study at any time. All participants gave consent before the data collection.

The interviews followed a semi-structured interview schedule based on Wylleman and Lavalée<sup>33</sup> and Wylleman<sup>34</sup> transition model, and especially the two dimensions athletic level, psychological level and reflecting previous research and literature on the normative transition from junior to senior (e.g. Stambulova).<sup>35</sup> Our focus was on transitions related to entering a professional academy in junior age, the time during which the players were part of the junior team (phase) and the transition out of the academy (e.g. into senior professional football). A pilot interview took place in November 2021 to test the interview schedule for missing topics and to check that the interview questions elicited the appropriate data needed to answer the research question. Every interview started with general questions intended to obtain background information and 'warm up' the participants to get the conversation started, and included questions aimed at capturing the parents and athletes' perceptions of the parents' role in their sports participation and commitment. Since our aim was towards transitions such as entering, during and potentially transition out of the academy, the main topic of the interview included questions aimed at capturing the parents and athletes' perceptions of the challenges the athletes faced when preparing for the athletic transitions. The interviews were audio-taped with the participants consents and were transcribed verbatim. The parent interviews lasted between 56 and 76 min and the players interviews between 29 and 36 min. The study was approved by the Norwegian Centre of Research Data [reference number: 580912] prior to the data collection.

The interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed. To provide anonymity, both parents and players were given identification codes, PA1-PA5 (Parent 1–Parent 5) and PL1-PL2 (Player 1–Player 5). The number from 1 to 5 also indicates which informants are related to each other (PA1 is the parent of PL1, etc.).

## Data analysis

Through this approach, we sought to gain an in-depth understanding of both the parents and the players experiences of parental support and influence on the players athletic development towards the goal of becoming a professional football player. The interviews had a specific focus on the social support the parents provided throughout the different stages of talent development, and how these

were perceived by the players and contributed to their development in a positive way or not, especially in the junior to senior transition.

The data analysis follows the six steps of a thematic analysis as suggested by Braun et al.<sup>36</sup> To initiate the process, the first author transcribed, read and re-read the data. Secondly, the first author conducted an inductive analysis to generate initial codes (e.g. Ambitions and expectations) which were then shared with the third author for critical feedback, where focus was on reflecting on the developed codes. The third phase was all about structuring the findings into higher-order themes. Emphasis was placed on understanding how both the players and parents understood the role and impact the parents had on the players in the transition into academy football and during the junior phase. In step four, the subthemes were discussed based on the athletic and psychosocial levels of Wylleman & Lavalée's<sup>37</sup> proposed developmental perspective on the preparations of the transitions. In the fifth step, these were then refined and labelled into the five main themes; 1. *Transition into the academy as a positive opportunity and a step to realizing the professional dream*, 2. *The transition into the professional academy structured for athlete development required adapting to a new sporting lifestyle, with new roles and the being 'one in the group'*, 3. *Transition out of the academy as a gradual process of reduced/realistic ambitions*, 4. *Changing role of parents: Shifting from active sport involvement to a more supportive role* and 5. *Parental support as unintended pressure*. Finally, representative quotes were chosen to reflect these themes in relation to the study aim and previous research (step 6).

Participants were given the opportunity to read through the transcribed material from the interview if they desired and make necessary changes to the transcribed material. No participants wanted to read through the material.

## Results

### ***Transition into the academy as a positive opportunity and a step to realizing the professional dream***

The initiation into a professional football academy was perceived by players as a favourable opportunity. Notably, the players all had ambitions to proceed to professional football and considered the academy as being on the right path to reach their ambitions. One of the players described his ambitions like this;

Yes, it's about becoming as good as possible. Playing in a good club in Europe, that's the goal. Making a living from football really (PL5).

Moreover, it was understood that the parents played an important role in supporting their decisions. For instance, player 4 acknowledged the impact of parental support, emphasizing the significance of seizing opportunities that do not come easily, particularly for a young boy navigating a pivotal choice (PL4).

*'( . . . ) they motivated me to take the chances you get. These opportunities don't come very often, so you just must take them to get good. No, what can I say, they supported me then, in making that choice, because it was quite a big choice'.*

Similar, parents 2 and 3 actively encouraged their sons to embrace the academy opportunity, emphasizing the importance of learning and versatility for the possibility of future success in professional football.

### ***The transition into the professional academy structured for athlete development required adapting to a new sporting lifestyle, with new roles and the being 'one in the group'***

The transition to a professional academy included access to top-level coaching, a strong support staff and better training facilities, providing a distinct advantage over their previous club. However, the transition into a professional academy also brought forth athletic challenges, notably the shift

from being a standout player in a former team to becoming average in the professional academy setting. This challenge was articulated by parents 1 and 2, who underscored the adjustment to a challenger position and the associated mental and social implications. Indeed, while the primary objective of joining a professional academy was to face challenges for personal football improvement, it also signified a shift in the players' familiar and secure surroundings.

He has faced the challenges of having to stand in a challenger position. At the end in his former club, before he came to the academy, he was one of the best. And when he enters there (the academy), he is far from being one of the best. Playing with national team players in almost every position, both younger and older, of course it's both a footballing challenge, but also a social and mental challenge. (PA2)

An additional challenge highlighted by the informants was the players' adaptation to new and potentially unwanted positions, posing difficulties in showcasing their optimal skills. Notably, the players had often held more central roles in their previous team (e.g. central midfielder), and the transition into the academy involved adapting to new positions due to increased competition in their preferred roles. Parent 2 discussed how he actively engaged with his son to address this challenge, fostering active communication with coaches and encouraging strategic approaches to playing in preferred positions.

### **Transition out of the academy as a gradual process of reduced/realistic ambitions**

The findings indicated that the junior–senior transition was not perceived as very difficult by the participants. Through the interviews, it became apparent that the ease of this transition was primarily attributed to the gradual realization among athletes that their professional dreams were fading. Two of the players (PL 1 and 4) described to lose their ambitions and ended up playing football for fun. The shift in expectations, from pursuing an elite professional career to engaging in recreational or semi-professional sports, meant that athletes could approach the transition with a more pragmatic mindset. Still, many of the players still had ambitions related to their career. Player 2 described this in the following:

*'It's always been about reaching as far as possible, and I want to play in the biggest league, in the Premier League in England, and that's still the case, but you have to set some short-term goals as well. For now, I hope to take the next step up to the OBOS league (second level) and from there to the next and then the next then. But definitely big goals still'.*

This change in perspective allowed for a smoother adaptation to a new sports context, as the pressure to compete at the highest level diminished. Consequently, most players experienced a transition characterized by minimal upheavals, such as a lack of significant changes in the competitive level.

### **Changing role of parents: shifting from active sport involvement to a more supportive role**

Through the interviews, it was understood that the parents had a high sport-specific involvement throughout their child's career. For instance, four out of the five parents had been a part of the coaching team in their child's former club. It was also understood that this double role as parents and coach could be problematic, and where some of the players considered their fathers to be 'harder' on the feedback compared to their teammates. However, as the players conducted the transition into the academy, parents also underwent a significant transformation in their roles. The newfound presence of skilled and professional coaches within the academy led to a decreased necessity for parental intervention in technical and tactical aspects of their training.

There will be other people who have more knowledge and things like that (PL5).

However, it was understood that the parents continued supporting their child's development through advice and counselling. For instance, player 2 reflected upon how his father helped him reflect upon his game.

*'The reflection part with dad, because it makes you very aware of what you must work on. If you don't know what you need to work on to get better, then you won't get anywhere'. Similarly, his father discussed 'I have also been very clear that you must ask the coach if there is anything you are wondering about, if you are doing it right or if you have understood the development goal or understood the task, or if you do not understand why he (the coach) replaced you, ask'.*

The one father with a background as a professional player had a different approach and stated that he was available to give feedback but stated that he trusted the coaches in the academy and the process;

He has access to competent coaches, so I have tried to leave it to them to help him (PA3).

Throughout the academy, parents transitioned into a more supportive role, emphasizing encouragement, emotional support and overall well-being. It was highlighted that this was especially important in difficult times. For instance, player 5 stated

*'They have wanted me to succeed, but also tried to support me if football doesn't go so well. For example, when you have bad periods, family is important. It is possible to talk to them and that they may be able to help you in a different way than just with football'.*

As the players realized the professional dream faded, the parents increasingly highlighted the child's self-worth is independent of athletic success and emphasizing the inherent benefits of participation in sport. Such as parent 1 expressing

*'it is important socially, the community, the friends you make, the network you get through it, (...) and the longer you keep at it, the better it is'.*

Parent 2 said

*'We've tried to tell [Player2] that we think he's a good person, even if it's that dream here or that fight there not always goes as he wishes. Then we probably also told him that it's not certain that that life there is that good'.*

Thus, the parents aimed at adjusting their involvement to meet their child's changing needs, changing from more sport-related involvement to more support. However, the parents stressed that their sport-involvement was mainly based on their sons' interests.

I don't know if I had any ambitions, more really wanted him to succeed because that's what he himself wants. I would probably have been just as happy if he had received an education or joined the military and received an education there. (...) It's just that you have some expectations that he will eventually have a good life. (PA5)

## Parental support as unintended pressure

The findings also revealed a paradoxical nature of parents' long-term positive support, where well-intentioned encouragement sometimes unintentionally created an implicit expectation for athletes to maintain intense sports involvement. While athletes perceived their parents' involvement as positive, it was also understood that acknowledging the substantial time and energy invested by parents in their athletic development resulted in athletes feeling a potential risk of disappointing their parents if expressing a desire to drop out of the pursuit of an elite soccer career or facing deselection. Consequently, the fear of disappointing their parents weighted in on their decisions regarding continued participation in the academy.

As one example, father 3 described

I'm not a pushy parent. My attitude is that people have to find out for themselves what they are willing to do. Feel free to come and ask, and I'll answer, but you must somehow feel it yourself, that it's something you want. It's something that has to come from within then, and I can't bear to nag at people if they don't feel like it, then I drop it either (PA3).

Although such description aligned with his son's perceptions, the son described how the positive involvement could result in additional unintended pressure – especially when facing challenges or setbacks;

When you feel that you are not performing, it is because you are not living up to other people's expectations. Especially when you have your parents on your side. That makes it a little more difficult, because you want to impress, but when you don't manage to do it, it just becomes an even heavier feeling. So it's probably not something they've done that makes it harder, it's probably just that they're involved as much as they are, that maybe the pressure is a little greater. The pressure to perform'.(PL3)

## Conclusion

The aim of the present study was to investigate the transition experiences of athletes engaged in a professional football academy, as well as the role parents may play during this period. Even though earlier research has studied youth sports (e.g. Dorsch et al.; Harwood et al.)<sup>38</sup> and elite sports (e.g. Knight et al.),<sup>39</sup> the football academy context in a professional football club remains underexplored. In total, the findings added to existing literature in pinpointing challenges related to transitions to a higher competitive level (e.g. a professional football academy), including the need for athletes to adjust to increased competitive level, new positions and to being 'one in the group' (Morris et al.).<sup>40</sup> Yet, the participants perceived the transition out of the academy as easier due to a gradual reduction in ambitions and expectations. Moreover, the parental involvement was largely perceived positively by athletes, aligning with existing recommendations regarding parental expertise, such as encouraging higher-level competitive experiences for their children when entering the academy, providing tangible, informational and emotional support and adapting their involvement and support to the stages of their children's development (e.g. Harwood & Knight).<sup>41</sup> Paradoxically, long-term positive support somewhat also unintentionally created an implicit pressure for athletes to perform and maintain intense sports involvement.

Given that many participants did not reach the professional level, one could question if the period in the junior team in the professional club could be considered optimal, including the parents-athlete relationship in the period. Despite the impact the coaches in an academy have on the players development, the parents' role and involvement could also impact the players 'new life'. This new life going into a professional football academy was described as being 'one in the group', as seen in earlier research.<sup>42</sup> The players had earlier in their career experienced a high degree of follow-up and involvement since four out of five parents had been coaches in their former clubs, even by some described as too hard follow-up in terms of feedback and expectations. This finding could also be related to a debate if the parent role is changing in the Scandinavian context, where the investment in children's sports activities has become a whole family activity, for some even considered an investment in a potential professional athlete's career. According to Stefansen et al.<sup>43</sup> a new generation of more involved sports parents has developed in Norwegian sports. This raises a potential discussion on how invested the parents should be, since they could be described as balancing on a thin line, between needed social and practical support and too much investment often characterized by high expectations and demands.

The follow-up and involvement could therefore be considered a two-edged sword since the players are depending on their parents' involvement, but that this involvement also might come with high expectations. Participants perceived the transition out of the academy as a gradual process of reduced ambitions, with the changing roles of parents, shifting from active involvement to a more supportive role, as seen in earlier research.<sup>44</sup> Even though the parents' roles shifted, some of the players description of their parental support ended up as unintended pressure for continuing their career, even though most parents described non-specific ambitions for their child to investment in football. The question would be if the support and involvement of the parents, which could be seen as positive, might have a negative impact on the players if

this involvement might include unintended pressure to ‘succeed’ or invest in football also after the academy period.

In most cases of academy players, the end of the academy period ends up with a transition out of the elite football and into grassroots level football.<sup>45</sup> A large group of players is entering football academies with a dream of ending up as a professional football player. The dream takes time to fulfil and even though academies invest a lot of time and effort in the players, young players development and progress are difficult to predict<sup>46</sup> and the number of spots in the senior professional team are few, coincidences might impact the players opportunities to reach their goal.<sup>47</sup> Given the limited success rate of players transitioning from academy football to elite football, the academies should systematically prepare the players for a life outside of elite football. This study wanted to address the players and their parents experience from entering a football academy and how they perceived the parents support in the junior phase both going in to, during and out of the academy context. The findings of this study offer valuable insights into the relational processes between athletes and their parents within a professional academy, providing information that can enhance and inform the Norwegian Academy Classification system, which has been criticized for traditionally overlooking these aspects.<sup>48</sup> Future studies should look closer on groups of players who make the transition into professional football in the junior to senior transition.

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